

Trap shooting

**MANAVIIT SINGH
SANDHU, 32**

Sandhu was signed up by the MCT after winning the World Trap Shooting Championship in 2006. A Chandigarh native, he believes that his career has coincided with the surge in Indian shooting.

"There's more depth and thoroughness in my training now."



BANDEEP SINGH

15 children from the 12,000 between the ages of 6 and 14 who registered for their selection clinics in four cities. NIIT's Mind Champion Academy (*see box*) has taken chess to more than 4,000 schools across India.

Former world billiards champion Sethi says, "Private enterprise can just be more efficient because they're smaller. I don't blame the government entirely, as they have so much else to look after." The government has been a well-meaning but somewhat woolly-headed shepherd to sport. It has lacked both the professional expertise needed to manage a rapidly-changing sector and the street-smartness required to deal with sports federations, the most notorious of whom dip into public funds with neither accountability nor much accounting.

Sandwiched in this tussle between government and its outdated administrative arm the Sports Authority of India (SAI) on one side, and the federations on the other, are athletes, their training cycles and career paths. The decades have ground on, the results have stayed the same. The sandwich has gone stale.

Programmes like the MCT and the OCG aim to be both intermediaries and fund-raisers, allies with government, federations, athletes and coaches, negotiators in territory and ego. At their best, what the programmes do for Indian athletes feels a little like liberation.

Boxer Kumar's career, which could have gone into freefall after a wrist injury, has been saved by an accurate diagnosis and an operation arranged by the MCT. Nehwal has been able to play in the 15 tournaments she thinks she needs to be ready for Beijing, all without worrying about raising funds for 10 events her federation may not be able to finance. Korean Lee Wang Woo, coach to eight Olympic gold medalists, now coaches Champia and other Indian archers on a six-year contract. Vikram Khade, father of Virdhawal, the fastest Indian in the water, sleeps better at night in Kolhapur, knowing that someone has picked up the slack after the family's funds had taken the son as far as they could—but nowhere close to where many believed his exceptional tal-

THE MITTAL'S CHAMPIONS TRUST, BACKED BY STEEL BARON LAKSHMI MITTAL, HAS COMMITTED \$10M (RS 44 CRORE) AND SUPPORTS 32 ATHLETES IN SEVEN DISCIPLINES.